

Mashups

Mashups are a combination of two or more web applications or APIs into a single web application. Head out to Webmashup.com for more

DBpedia

DBpedia is an effort to consolidate all the information on Wikipedia to be used as smart resources by Web 3.0 apps. Contribute at wiki.dbpedia.org

Feature

and soon died out for various reasons. To post images online, a few tech-savvy users relied on software that churned out HTML web galleries. A few services like Geocities and Angelfire allowed users to create and upload their own content, but this too required an understanding of HTML, and how hosts work. For a good ten years, this was the web, but dramatic changes were in the offing behind the scenes.

Ward Cunningham was working on a system that allowed users to edit databases, and quickly change and generate content. A Harvard kid with a laptop called Mark Zuckerberg was contemplating comparing his friends to farm animals, and have his buddies vote between the two. A company called Ludicorp was thinking of ways in which users could chat and pool photos at the same time, while playing their online multiplayer game. Pyra labs was working on a setup that allowed users to easily create and generate content in the form of online journals. These ideas were dormant for some time, and needed some kind of a catalyst. Something that fundamentally shifted the way the web was used. That came along, as a major reality check for the web in the form of the dot com bubble burst.

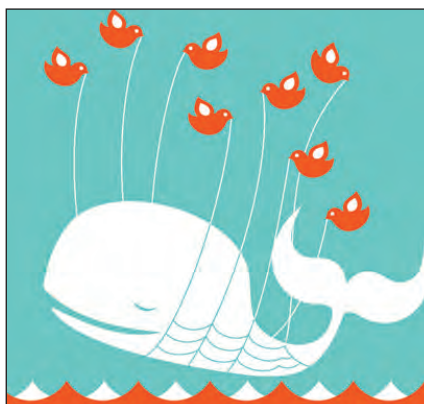


Handyman services

Web sites could no longer set up interesting portals, or put up content and expect to earn money. The focus shifted to getting users actively involved in the process of content generation. Wikis, so far used for side projects and coding communities, emerged as a massive political statement in the face of online reference web sites such as Encarta and gave them a run for their money. A simple method for editing, and creating content ballooned out of proportion, and became the *de facto* authority for gaining information online. Yahoo! bought off Flickr from Ludicorp, as a platform for sharing and pooling photos, and Google came up with its own Picasa Web as an image hosting solution. Stumble Upon and Digg, both small services, occupied the same space as the search giant Google for being windows to the web. Facebook spread from Ivy League collages in the US to the general population as a powerful platform for social interaction. Blogger was bought out by Google, and became a platform for everything from meaningless meandering to citizen journalism, an independent source of news and ideas that soon became mainstream. YouTube became the web's equivalent of television, offering almost any kind of video content on demand. Recently, Twitter emerged as another powerful platform that has managed to achieve so much by encouraging users to post so little.

Can you spot something fundamentally

common to all these services? Not just the fact that all of these heavily depend on the users to create content - user generated material on Facebook, for example, can hardly be called content. These are not just web sites, these are platforms, and can be consumed in more ways than simply navigating to a particular URL. The key words here are tags, feeds, APIs, widgets. You can write applications that interface with the wealth of data in Facebook, Twitter or Flickr, you can navigate through the content on Stumble Upon and Blogger through a feed reader on your desktop, you can post videos from YouTube or songs from Grooveshark in your blog's sidebar by copying some lines of code. Many Twitter users have never seen the Fail Whale graphic of Twitter,



The Fail Whale is seen everytime Twitter goes down

and have never even gone to Twitter.com. To them, Twitter exists only on their mobile phones. The possibilities of how to use these platforms are not limited to what the creators of these web sites could think of. They are open to the world, to do what they want to do with them. The technology driving the web is no longer restricted to browsers, or even web pages. HTML already feels like stone age technology, because of how much the fabric of the web has evolved within two decades of the web's existence.

Rewiring the web



JavaScript, AJAX, LAMP, PHP, Flash, Silverlight and Air are the most common technologies used in Web 2.0. These are not merely improved ways of allowing web browsers to display more eye candy on screen, although this has definitely happened. Instead, they are ways and means by which users can interact with the web better. Most of these services form another sphere, a content rich network in its own right, another layer above the web itself. The Blogosphere, the network on Facebook, and the Tweetosphere are not named because

of some kind of fad or to better promote these services. These are real worlds, changing the social, political and economic landscapes. The web is no longer made up of static pages of information. Instead, the web is now made up of dynamic platforms and applications, which are two different things. There are many, invisible ways in which the web has changed. Creating, designing and maintaining web sites takes much more time, effort and money now, than it used to. The process has become much more complicated instead of simpler, and the end user is often oblivious of these shifts in the way sites and services on the web are conceived.

Think of an application that you run on your computer. Every time you click on something, the computer checks the memory for further instructions, and changes the screen according to your input. On the web, this was a different story. Your input data would be compressed, transferred to a server where it would be processed, and thrown back at you. Web 2.0 uses a bunch of technologies to reduce this difference between applications run on the desktop, and applications run through a browser. A portion of the processing is done on your machine, while another chunk is done at the server. However, users no longer have to wait while a set of instructions are sent to the server, and can continue to use the service. Instead of the entire page refreshing, portions of the same page change now, once a web site is loaded. Online image editing applications such as Pixlr, or services such as Google Maps are examples of this shift. You might have noticed how search suggestions on Google change in real time while you search. This was something undreamed of in the original implementation of the web. Web 2.0 is about *now* - what is trending right now on Twitter, what is happening right now in your friend circle on Facebook, what is the buzz in the blogosphere right now. Things have started "happening" online. Another major introduction is the use of third-party applications with a platform. It's fairly simple, for example to make a slideshow screensaver of all the images on Flickr with a particular tag, and scroll text of Twitter or Blogger entries of the same tag over these images. Open APIs are not only a way to encourage more users to get personal with the web service or application, they are a way to use the pool of content in new and interesting ways. Another shift is in how much Web 2.0 allows people to collaborate on projects. Web sites such as Jamendo, Sourceforge, OPsound and Vimeo allow users to create, share, distribute and remix music, videos and software. This is where the web stands right now, and this was the approach desktop



Read up on what businesses can do on Web 2.0 <http://www.thinkdigit.com/d/88212/>